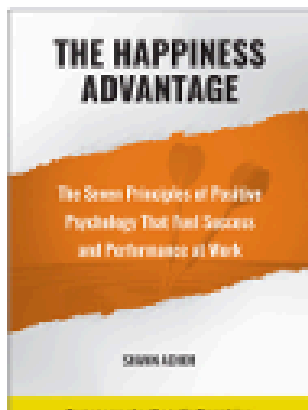




THE HAPPINESS ADVANTAGE

The Seven Principles of Positive Psychology
that Fuel Success and Performance at Work

SHAWN ACHOR

The Big “So What”



Happiness has been found to be an important predictor of success. In this book, Achor presents a set of 7 proven positive psychology tools that can improve your resilience, happiness, well-being and performance.

Introduction



Many of us have been brought up on the belief that success brings happiness—we think we’ll only be happy if we get that promotion, if we lose that next 5 pounds, and so on. Yet, today, there’s ample scientific research to show that happiness drives success, not vice versa. When you’re happy and positive, you tend to be more motivated, resilient, creative and efficient, which in turn improves your results. This is the “Happiness Advantage”.

There’s also extensive evidence that the human brain changes throughout our lives. This means that everything from your intellectual capacity to personal potential can be changed. From his research, Achor found 7 positive psychology principles which were proven to help people from various walks of life—from Harvard students to professionals and Fortune 500 executives—to overcome challenges, improve productivity and unlock their potential.

The 7 Positive Psychology Principles



Principle #1: Tap on the Happiness Advantage



Train your brain to become more positive, as it gives you a natural advantage over being neutral or negative.

KEY QUOTES

“Happiness and optimism actually fuel performance and achievement—giving us the competitive edge that I call the Happiness Advantage.”

“Happiness is not the belief that we don’t need to change; it is the realization that we can.”

“Small positive interventions (can) create sustainable, longterm change at work.”



What's happiness? There's no universal definition for happiness. Generally, it's a state of subjective well-being that involves a positive mood in the moment and a positive viewpoint for the future. In this book, Achor uses "happiness" interchangeably with words like "positivity" and "positive emotions".



There are many studies to show that happiness brings better health, success and achievement (and not the other way round).

- Learning and creativity. Positive emotions release dopamine and serotonin in our brains to improve our learning capacity. They also improve our peripheral vision so we literally see more things around us. Students and young children who were feeling happy performed much better at tests and learning tasks than their peers who were feeling neutral or negative. People who were feeling amused or contented thought of more ideas than people feeling angry or anxious.
- Performance. Positive emotions increase your chances of success by (i) improving your ability to conceptualize new solutions and (ii) alleviating physical symptoms of stress and anxiety (e.g. increased heart rates or blood pressure). By thinking about something that makes you happy just before a stressful exam or presentation, you can prime yourself for better performance.
- Health. Nuns with more joyful journal entries (which indicate a positive disposition) were found to live almost 10 years longer than those with negative or neutral entries. Unhappy employees were also found to take 15 more sick days a year compared to their colleagues.



We all have different "happiness baselines", i.e. some people are naturally happier than others. However, **you can use these proven practices to boost short-term emotions and permanently increase your happiness baseline.**

- Meditate. Meditation has been found to grow the left prefrontal cortex—the part of our brain with the greatest impact on happiness levels. By taking 5 minutes daily to meditate and focus on your breathing, you can reduce stress, improve happiness and even immunity over time.
- Look forward to a future reward (e.g. a movie or a vacation)—the anticipation alone can boost your endorphin levels so you feel as happy as when you enjoy the actual reward.

KEY QUOTES

"Happiness causes success and achievement, not the opposite."

"Even the smallest shots of positivity can give someone a serious competitive edge."

"Happiness is not just a mood—it's a work ethic."

- Perform 5 deliberate acts of kindness daily. Altruistic acts (e.g. giving to friends or strangers) have been found to reduce stress and improve mental health.
- Inject positivity into your environment, which has a huge impact on your mindset and well-being. Surround your workspace with pictures of loved ones, go for a walk on a nice day, and watch fewer negative TV programs.
- Exercise—be it walking, biking, or playing—triggers the release of endorphins, reduces stress and improves motivation. Exercise is as effective as antidepressant medication in the short term, and even more effective than medication in the long-term.
- Invest in meaningful experiences, as they bring more lasting happiness than pleasure from material acquisitions (i.e. buying things for yourself).
- Use a signature strength. It feels good to apply a core skill. Identify your top 5 strengths on www.viasurvey.org and use at least 1 key strength each day.



Lead with the Happiness Advantage. Leaders can create huge ripple effects because they can (i) shape the company policies/culture, (ii) act as a role model and (iii) influence their team members directly. Unfortunately, in many organizations, leaders dismiss the need for happiness and even frown on people laughing or taking breaks from work.

- The Happiness Advantage is a useful tool for motivating your team and unlocking staff potential. By using small gestures (e.g. giving encouragement or providing recreational options), you can generate positive feelings to trigger the advantage. Google provides scooters, video games and gourmet food for its staff while Toyota uses strength-based training. Coors Brewing Company saw a return of >6x from its corporate fitness programs alone.
- Leaders' tone of voice and body language also impact others, e.g. a message delivered with an angry, annoyed or indifferent tone could affect staff morale and performance.
- Stay above the Losada Line. Marcial Losada discovered that for an organization to work well, there must be approximately 3 positive interactions for every negative interaction. Team

KEY QUOTES

"Physical activity is not just an incredibly powerful mood lifter, but a long-lasting one."

"Each time we use a skill, whatever it is, we experience a burst of positivity."

"By changing the way you work, and the way you lead the people around you, you can enhance the success of your team and your whole organization."

"Even the smallest moments of positivity in the workplace can enhance efficiency, motivation, creativity, and productivity."

"Just as important as what you say to employees is how you say it."

performance suffers when you fall below the Losada Line and peaks when you hit the ideal ratio of 6:1 positive-to-negative interactions.

Principle #2: Change outcomes with your fulcrum and lever



Famous scientist and mathematician Archimedes theorized that with a long-enough lever and the right fulcrum, a man could single-handedly move the world. Your mindset is like your fulcrum while your belief is like your lever. **By shifting your mindset and extending your belief of what's possible, you can magnify your ability to create what originally seemed impossible.**



Your mindset (the fulcrum). Reality isn't cast in stone; it's merely your subjective understanding of the world. **By changing your mindset, you can change your perceived reality and how you respond to it.**

- Everyone has 24 hours a day; your mindset defines how much you achieve with your time. People with positive mindsets tend to work more productively and energetically, e.g. they may find meaning in a mundane activity by challenging themselves to do it better or trying to learn something in the process. They also tend to use their leisure time to recharge and enrich themselves. On the other hand, those with negative mindsets drag themselves through work and treat leisure activities as a waste of time.
- Your mindset is so powerful that it can change the concrete outcomes from your subjective experiences. In an experiment, a group of 75 year old men were told to dress, speak, act and live as if they had travelled back in time to when they were 55 years old. After just 1 week, most of the men showed an improvement in physical appearance, flexibility, strength, eyesight, and/or mental capabilities. Placebos have been found to be 55-60% as effective as real medication or treatments—people experienced hair growth and reduced knee swelling even when they were given placebo drugs and fake surgery. On the other hand, people who thought they had come into contact with poison ivy actually developed physical symptoms (e.g. boils, redness and itching).



Your beliefs (the lever). **Your belief about your potential defines what you can achieve.** Accountants' belief in their ability/

KEY QUOTES

"Give me a lever long enough and a fulcrum on which to place it, and I shall move the world."
- Archimedes

"Our mindset, and in turn our experience of the world, is never set in stone, but constantly in flux."

"Mindset doesn't just change how we feel about an experience—it actually changes the objective results of that experience."

"The mental construction of our daily activities, more than the activity itself, defines our reality."

"The more you believe in your own ability to succeed, the more likely it is that you will."

potential was found to predict their job performance better than their skill level/training. Women who were told they had superior math abilities did much better than those who were told they had inferior abilities.

- Believe in your abilities. While prior preparation is important, your mental state directly affects your in-the-moment performance. During a difficult task, you'll perform better if you focus on your strengths or the reasons you'll succeed.
- Believe you can improve your abilities. Carol Dweck found that people with a growth mindset consistently out-perform those with a fixed mindset. The former believe that skills, abilities and temperaments can be changed, so they take every opportunity to learn and improve. The latter believe they can't change and thus let opportunities slip by.



Find your calling. Amy Wrzesniewski found that employees can have 3 mindsets about work: they can see it as a *job* (a chore to earn a salary), a *career* (a means to achieve success) or a *calling* (a way to use their strengths to contribute meaningfully).

- People who see their work as a calling are more likely to work longer and harder at it, resulting in higher chances of success. On the other hand, telling people their work is meaningless is a sure way to demotivate them.
- How you see your work depends on your mindset, not the job nature. A janitor with a job-orientation may find it a chore to clean up others' mess while a janitor with a calling-orientation may feel satisfied to provide a clean environment for others.
- Instead of using a job description, try writing a "calling description" to describe the meaning from your work (e.g. how you're impacting others) and how it helps you to achieve your wider goals.



You can influence others' mindset and beliefs simply by changing your choice of words to convey faith and encouragement instead of cynicism and doubt.

- Your expectations of someone can affect their actual performance, a phenomenon called the Pygmalion Effect. In an experiment, teachers were told that certain students had

KEY QUOTES

"By changing the way we perceive ourselves and our work, we can dramatically improve our results."

"Beliefs are so powerful because they dictate our efforts and actions."

"You can have the best job in the world, but if you can't find the meaning in it, you won't enjoy it."

"Even the smallest tasks can be imbued with greater meaning when they are connected to personal goals and values."

higher academic potential when these were just ordinary students. Due to the teachers' high expectations, the students ended up with superior results. At the workplace, people also tend to act the way we expect them to.

- If you're a leader, ask yourself 3 questions regularly: (i) Do I believe my staff can improve their abilities? (ii) Do I believe my staff want to invest the effort and do meaningful work? and (iii) How am I conveying these beliefs via my words and actions?

Principle #3: Create a Positive Tetris Effect



The Tetris Effect occurs when we spend so much time and attention on something that it changes our thoughts, mental images, and behaviors. It was named after the phenomenon of people seeing their world in Tetris blocks (e.g. constantly thinking how buildings or items may fit together) after they've played the game for too long. **Train your brain to see positive patterns (like possibilities and opportunities) instead of the negatives (like stress and failure).**



Your brain naturally filters out as much as 99% of the environmental inputs you receive. What it takes in or filters out depends on what you train it to focus on.

- "Inattentional blindness" refers to our tendency to be oblivious to something we're not focusing on, even if it's right in front of us. In a famous experiment, people were asked to count the number of times the white team passed the ball in a basketball game. They were so focused the ball that 46% failed to notice a person walking across the screen for 5 seconds in a gorilla costume.
- On the other hand, when we focus on something, we tend to see it everywhere. If you've decided to buy a certain car model, you'd suddenly notice it everywhere.



Our predominant work habits can shape our brain's thinking patterns so much that it spills over to our personal life. Tax auditors who spend hours at work looking for errors tend to focus on their kids'/spouses' mistakes at home. Athletes can't help competing with others while financial traders can't help assessing the risks in everything. Beware of such negative Tetris Effects.

KEY QUOTES

"Spam filters, whether in our heads or our e-mail, scan only for what they are programmed to find."

"We tend to miss what we're not looking for."



Different people see different things in the same situation, not only because of their interpretation but because of what they actually notice.

- Two groups of people were asked to count the number of photos in newspapers. The group that believed they were lucky finished the task quickly as they saw at least 1 of 2 planted messages telling them they could stop. Those who believed they were unlucky failed to see the opportunities right in front of them and missed both messages.
- In both work and life, those with positive cognitive patterns are more likely to recognize and take up an opportunity when it comes along, while the opposite holds true for those with negative cognitive patterns.



Create the Positive Tetris Effect by training your brain to look for opportunities and ideas that increase your success, instead of the negatives that block success.

- Do this simple daily exercise: write down specifically 3 good things in your work or life, e.g. the friendly driver who helped you with your luggage or that wonderful dinner with your spouse. This trains your brain to notice and focus on the positives while pushing the negatives to the background. This exercise has been found to improve happiness levels over 1-6 months, with sustained effects even after people stop doing it.
- You can vary the exercise by writing a long daily entry about a positive experience. Make it easier by ritualizing it (e.g. doing it at the same time and place daily) or involving others (e.g. doing it with your team or spouse).
- Creating a positive Tetris Effect doesn't mean you should shut out all negatives and become blind to problems. Wear rose-tinted glasses, not blindfolds.

Principle #4: Fall upward



During crisis and failures, we typically have 3 mental paths: (i) we keep dwelling on our current situation, (ii) we think about worst-case scenarios, or (iii) we find the upward path that brings us out of the dumps into a stronger position than before. **Learn to find the third mental path so you can emerge stronger and happier from setbacks.**

KEY QUOTES

"It's not your age, or what you do for a living; it's the training and consistency that count."

"The ideal mindset isn't heedless of risk, but it does give priority to the good."

"Our ability to find the Third Path is the difference between those who are crippled by failure and those who rise above it."



Finding the path to success. Studies show that people who see failure and disasters as an opportunity to grow and learn are more likely to find creative ways to rebound from their setbacks. On the other hand, people who stop searching for solutions lose the ability to overcome challenges and keep sliding downward.

- Some people who experience trauma end up with Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD) while others experience Post-Traumatic Growth (to feel greater compassion, spirituality, strength etc.). The difference lies in how they perceive the trauma.
- During economic downturns, companies that focus on streamlining their operations and creating new solutions tend to pull ahead of those who focus on lost opportunities.



Use these strategies to find the upward path:

- Change your counterfactuals, or the explanation you create about what happened and why. Imagine you fell down the stairs and broke an arm—you could think you were unlucky to get injured, or you could think you were lucky not to get a more serious injury. You can always choose your counterfactuals.
- Adopt a more optimistic explanatory style, so you see your failures as specific and temporary ("I made a mistake this time"), rather than global and permanent ("I'm just too stupid"). Studies have found that people who adopt the former approach tend to learn from their mistakes while the latter simply give up.
- Even if you've experienced a real disaster, you can decatastrophize the event by looking for alternative counterfactuals and considering the long-term impact, which is usually not as bad as you think.

Principle #5: Regain control with the Zorro Circle



We find the best solutions when we can think clearly and creatively. Unfortunately, in times of crisis, all logic goes out of the window.

Legend says that the masked hero, Zorro, mastered the sword by training in a small circle. The Zorro Circle represents our "circle of control". **When things are spiralling out of control, refocus on small, manageable goals, then gradually expand your circle as you rebuild your confidence and control.**

KEY QUOTES

"The most successful people see adversity not as a stumbling block, but as a stepping stone to greatness."

"When people don't believe there is a way up, they have virtually no choice but to stay as down as they are."

"Our fear of consequences is always worse than the consequences themselves."

"Adversity never hits us quite as hard—or for quite as long—as we think it might."



Why we lose control. Our brain has (i) an emotional center (governed mainly by the amygdala) which triggers our instinctive responses, and (ii) a logical center (governed mainly by the prefrontal cortex) which rationalizes our options before we act.

- In the cavemen age, if you're faced with a lion, there'd be no time to analyze your options; your amygdala would flood your body with hormones to spark a "fight or flight" response.
- Today, we seldom face such time-critical dangers. Yet, when we're extremely stressed, our involuntary biological responses take over and we get emotionally hijacked. When this happens, we can't think clearly, tend to lash out at others, feel helpless and/or take drastic actions.



Perceived control. When you believe you're in control of your fate and outcomes, you tend to be happier, less stressed, and more motivated. The actual amount of control you have is less important than how much control you *think* you have. When elderly in a nursing home were given control over simple daily tasks (e.g. caring for their house plants), mortality rates actually fell by 50%.



How to regain control, 1 circle at a time:

- Develop self-awareness: The simple act of putting your feelings into words can reduce the impact of the negative feelings.
- List down (i) aspects of the situation you can control vs (ii) aspects that you can't control. Identify 1 small goal you can achieve quickly. By focusing your energy and effort on 1 task, you increase your chances of success and regain a sense of control.
- Expand your circle of control gradually, going for goals of mid-difficulty so you still must push yourself but won't feel so overwhelmed that you give up. Don't set unrealistic goals that'd backfire and demoralize you.

Principle #6: Transform habits with the 20-Second Rule



Almost everyone understands the value of a healthy diet, exercise and rest. Yet, most people don't do it. Even if you want to nurture positivity,

KEY QUOTES

"When our brain hits the panic button, reason goes out the window and our wallets, our careers, and our bottom lines all suffer."

"Feeling that we are in control, that we are masters of our own fate at work and at home, is one of the strongest drivers of both well-being and performance."

"Small successes can add up to major achievements. All it takes is drawing that first circle in the sand."

"Common sense is not common action."

it's hard to break existing habits to create lasting change. **Use the path of least resistance to replace bad habits with good ones.**



We're creatures of habit. Most of our daily actions—from clothing ourselves to brushing our teeth—are habits that we don't consciously think about. The best way to sustain positive change is to convert a desired behavior into an automatic habit.

- How habits are formed. Each time you do something, it sparks electrical currents between the billions of neurons in our brains. When you do something regularly, it reinforces specific neural pathways, allowing the currents to move faster until the behavior seems second-nature to you. It may be hard to coordinate your movements when you first learn to juggle, but with practice the movements become automatic.
- Overcoming inertia. It's human nature to follow the path of least resistance and stick with "default" options, e.g. using the default ringtone on the phone or buying items placed at eye level (instead of those at the top or bottom shelves). When you force yourself to do something, it takes willpower; and willpower gets depleted with use. That's why it's so hard to break a habit—you must repeatedly invest physical and mental energy until the habit is changed.



Use this strategy to form new habits: Put your desired habit on the path of least resistance. Add 20 seconds of extra effort to a habit you want to break, and reduce the effort for the new habit you want to form.

- For example, to stop snacking on chocolates, keep them in a container on an upper shelf so it takes 20 extra seconds to reach them. Concurrently place fresh fruits on the kitchen counter within easy reach. To watch less TV, remove the batteries from the remote control and keep them in your bedroom drawer. Concurrently place a book next to the couch so you're more likely to pick it up.
- Set rules in advance so you won't need to make a decision each time and reduce the chances you'd go off-course.

KEY QUOTES

"Habits are like financial capital—forming one today is an investment that will automatically give out returns for years to come."

"Your brain, once it has tipped toward a habit, will naturally keep rolling in that direction, following the path of perceived least resistance."

Principle #7: Invest in social support



In times of difficulty and stress, we need social support more. Yet we tend to bury ourselves in work and reduce our time with friends and family. **Invest in social support, which is one of the biggest predictor of success and happiness, and your greatest asset.**



Our social interactions (with spouse, family, friends, colleagues etc.) generate positive feelings and deepen relationships, both of which improve our happiness baseline, well-being and performance. Positive social interactions lead to the release of oxytocin, a pleasure-inducing hormone that reduces stress and improves focus. Social connections also improve our cardiovascular, neuroendocrine, and immune systems. On the other hand, the lack of social support/contact can hurt life expectancy as much as smoking, high blood pressure and obesity.



To build your social capital:

- Create high-quality connections e.g. greet colleagues with eye contact, remember things about them like their interests or the names of their children.
- Show support in good times (not just bad times). When someone shares a piece of good news, respond with enthusiasm and interest e.g. "That's great news! I'm glad your work is being recognized. When will your promotion take effect?" Passive responses (e.g. "That's cool") or negative responses ("Oh, I thought the promotion would go to Ben") can be harmful, and the worst response is to ignore the good news altogether.



Employees with strong bonds to their manager tend to perform better and stay longer. As a leader, you can strengthen your personal connections directly and build an environment that nurtures social relationships.

- Create opportunities for employees from different departments to interact and connect. Go beyond formal work titles to recognize people's contributions, personal interests etc. Give people your full attention during a conversation (instead of looking at your phone) and move around for face-to-face interactions and acknowledge people's work.

KEY QUOTES

"When we encounter an unexpected challenge or threat, the only way to save ourselves is to hold on tight to the people around us and not let go."

"The more social support you have, the happier you are. And as we know, the happier you are, the more advantages you accrue in nearly every domain of life."

"Like our stocks, social support networks grow stronger the longer they are held."

"The best leaders give their employees the space and time to let moments of social connection develop on their own."

- Google provides cafes where employees can interact, and encourages its staff to visit their kids at the on-site day care. UPS encourages its truck-drivers to meet up for lunch while Southwest Airlines and Domino's Pizza allow their staff to offer donations for colleagues with medical or financial emergencies.

Creating a Positive Ripple Effect



All 7 principles above are closely intertwined and will create a larger synergistic effect when applied together. **The best way to create a massive impact is not to preach to others and hope they'll change. Instead, apply the principles to change yourself; in so doing, you'll naturally create a positive ripple effect.**

- Our brains contain mirror neurons that sense and imitate others' feelings, actions and sensations. When you give someone a genuine smile, the other person can't help but mirror it back to you, which in turn improves your own positive feelings. This mirror effect is so powerful that 1 positive team member can change the dynamics of an entire group.
- In fact, our attitudes, words and actions are so contagious that they affect people up to 3 degrees of influence. For example, when you leave a positive impact on your child, you'll also indirectly impact her friends and their parents.

Other Details in the Book to Look out For



In the book, Achor shares many other empirical research and examples to help us understand the foundations of positive psychology and how the 7 principles are derived and applied.

For more details, please visit www.shawnachor.com/the-books/the-happiness-advantage.

KEY QUOTES

"The person we have the greatest power to change is ourselves."

"Practicing the seven principles in your own life can actually become your most effective leadership tool, without your even knowing it."